period of the Shansabanis' emergence as a regional power in the twelfth century *required* cultural patronage, including architecture, wherein so many of the religious, intellectual, and juridical supports of rule were housed (see esp. Chapter 1). But rather than viewing architecture as solely an instantaneous phenomenon, being the monumental result of elite patronage, a perception of the built form within its larger nexus of processes of facture, varying uses, and shifting receptions all together aid in accessing a wider cross-section of its historical significances. Indeed, precisely *because* command and mobilization of skilled labor was requisite in the creation of built works, these serve as diagnostic points of reference for the emergence of new politico-economic elites – that is, previously unknown groups who came to possess the political and material capital required to have buildings constructed for them. Akin to Sana'i's elephant, then, discrete aspects of the built work hold immense potential for differing yet complementary insights into its milieu, and the groups of people who interacted with it throughout its existence (see, e.g., Chapter 2).

But, as modern investigators attempting to access a past, how might we understand the architectural "product" that historical patrons were underwriting, either through command or compensation? What were the range of standards that circumscribed its outcome? I propose the concept of *architectural culture* as an accommodating heuristic device to apprehend the collective span of the built works analyzed herein.

The writings of J. Sourdel-Thomine (e.g., 1960, *inter alia*) and M. Meister (esp. 1993, 2011) regarding "style," "idiom," and "mode" have initiated the difficult but essential process of coming to grips with coalescing patterns in the history of material–cultural production. These scholars had – very responsibly – applied their observations to their respective regions of expertise, Sourdel-Thomine distilling her long experience in the eastern Islamic world (greater Khurasan), and Meister his equally profound engagement with the building traditions spanning the Indus's alluvia through the north Indian plains. Collectively, these authors' writings are not merely relevant to the regions encompassed within the emerging Shansabani elites' annexations, they have formed the bases for my conception of architectural culture as a complex of constitutive mechanisms shaping their respective built environments, in turn allowing us to address the nature of the Shansabanis' participation within them.

This Volume and the next argue that the Shansabanis' territories – eventually extending into north India – encompassed three distinct and equally significant architectural cultures: modern central through western Afghanistan, interconnected with historical Khurasan; the Indus' alluvia; and the Indo-Gangetic plains.[44] The building groups located in these regions did not simply look different from each other: They were in fact convergent indices of several factors, including indigenous natural resources; materials of construction; architectural traditions and their